Methods Report - Methodenbericht

Sabine Einwiller, University of Vienna, Email: sabine.einwiller@univie.ac.at

Dan Laufer, Victoria University Wellington, Email: dan.laufer@vuw.ac.nz

Project title: Effects of news coverage on a victim's character during a crisis

Method: Experiment

Experimental Design: One-factorial experiment with two conditions manipulating the reporting on irrelevant information on the crisis victim's bad character (n=79 inappropriate sexual behavior; n=83 alcohol problems) plus a control condition (n=83 no such information).

Universe: Consumers in the UK (18 years +)

Sample: 245 consumers from the UK. Their age ranged from 18 to 88 years (M = 45.73, SD = 16.38), 48.6 percent were female and 51 percent were male; 0.4 percent reported "other" as gender (one participant).

Data collection period: Oct 18 – 22, 2021

Stimuli: Three versions of a newspaper article by a fictitious media outlet named Chicago Herald were created on the United Airlines crisis. Two versions included information on the victim's bad character which were to be compared with a third version, the control condition without such information.

Data collection procedure: Participants were recruited through an online panel provider based in the UK. After reading the informed consent information and agreeing to participate, participants were randomly assigned to one of the three conditions. After reading the article, participants were asked to fill out a questionnaire containing 1) the manipulation checks, 2) the dependent variables as well as the 3) questions regarding demographics.

Manipulation checks

Journalistic quality, drawing on Prochazka et al. (2018)

Perception of *fairness of victim's depiction* in the article, developed by the authors

Perception of the *relevance of the information on the victim,* developed by the authors

Dependent variables

Blame attribution, drawing on scales by Oliver (1997) and Laufer et al. (2005)

Airline reputation, drawing on scales for brand attitude (Spears and Singh 2004) and consumer trust (Sirdeshmukh, Singh, and Sabol 2002)

Newspaper reputation, drawing on scales for brand attitude (Spears and Singh 2004) and consumer trust (Sirdeshmukh, Singh, and Sabol 2002)

Empathy with the victim, scale developed by Cehajic, Brown, and Gonzales (2009)

Victim reputation, scale developed by Lee and Oh (2012)

At the end of the survey, participants were asked for *demographic information* related to their gender, age and highest level of education

Sources for scales

Cehajic, S., Brown, R., & Gonzales, R. (2009). What do I Care? Perceived Ingroup Responsibility and Dehumanization as Predictors of Empathy Felt for the Victim Group. *Group Processes & Intergroup Relations, 12*(6), 715–729. https://doi.org/10.1177/1368430209347727

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Sirdeshmukh, D., Singh, J., & Sabol, B. (2002). Consumer Trust, Value, and Loyalty in Relational Exchanges. *Journal of Marketing, 66*(1), 15-37. https://doi.org/10.1509/jmkg.66.1.15.18449

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